



Doug Suttles,
CEO & Co-Founder
of Ookla

Internet during the pandemic

Doug Suttles, CEO & Co-Founder of Ookla, sheds some light on the internet use in India during the pandemic

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To say COVID-19 changed the way the world functions would be an understatement. Since the pandemic hit, staying and working from home has become the norm. As such, this put a greater need on internet services as more and more people turned towards online services for their social and professional needs. This, of course, got us thinking, what was the change in internet traffic before and after the pandemic? What was the trend in India? Will internet consumption ever go back to the way things were?

To get these answers, we got in touch with Doug Suttles, the CEO and Co-Founder of Ookla. While the company is probably best known for its Speedtest platform, it also offers a

host of analytical data which can help us get the answers we wanted.

Q Can you shed light on the growth in internet usage during the pandemic?

Suttles: At Ookla, we've seen a massive increase in the number of tests taken with Speedtest by Indian users that coincide with the pandemic and the need of Indian users to secure adequate bandwidth during lockdowns. At the onset of the national lockdown in India, in the third week of March 2020, the Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI) claimed that operators had recorded a 30% jump in traffic. Most of the traffic was from people streaming video. This is equivalent to the scale of increase you'd typically see over an entire year. It prompted the COAI to write to streaming services and ask them to reduce the bitrate of their content. According to Nokia, India saw mobile data traffic growth of 36% in 2020 and now sits at approximately 14.6 GB per user per month.

Q Was this global trend followed in India? What was the change we saw

in terms of fixed-line and mobile internet speeds?

Suttles: We saw internet speeds decline in many parts of the world during the onset of the pandemic, which was linked to lockdowns and the resultant surge in the demand for data. Internet speeds in India were no different, declining in the early stages of the pandemic. For example, according to Speedtest Intelligence, median mobile download speeds, which were 8.11 Mbps in February 2020 before lockdown, fell to 6.02 Mbps in April. Fixed internet speeds also fell, but to a lesser degree. The good news is that performance has picked up since then, which is a testament to continued operator investment. Median mobile download speeds increased from 10.64 Mbps in Q1 2020 to 15.67 Mbps in Q2 2021. 4G Service (the % of an operator's known locations where a device has access to 4G LTE service) hit 97% in the same quarter, which is up from 93.5% at the end of 2020.

Q Did broadband penetration increase? Can you share some data on the same?

Suttles: Broadband connections fell